

Naming and Necessity — The Gödel/Schmidt Case

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Suppose the "simple case" is actually true (Schmidt discovered the theorem, and Gödel took credit). Does it follow that when "our ordinary man" uses the name "Gödel," he really refers to Schmidt?

I don't think so. According to Kripke, it does not follow that the speaker refers to Schmidt. Even if the only thing the "ordinary man" believes about Gödel is that "he discovered the incompleteness of arithmetic," he is still referring to Gödel (the person who took the credit) and not Schmidt (the actual discoverer).

To begin with, If the Descriptivist view (Frege/Russell) were correct, reference would be determined by the description "the discoverer of the theorem." Since Schmidt is the only one who fits this description, the name "Gödel" would have to refer to Schmidt.

Failure of Descriptivism

Moreover, Kripke argues that our linguistic intuition suggests otherwise. If the "ordinary man" says, "Gödel discovered the incompleteness theorem," we judge this statement to be **false**. However, if "Gödel" referred to Schmidt, the statement would be **true** (since Schmidt did discover it). The fact that we consider the statement false proves that we are still talking about Gödel. **The Intuition of Falsehood**

Besides, Kripke proposes that reference is fixed not by descriptions in the speaker's head, but by a **causal chain of communication**. The name "Gödel" was passed from person to person, starting from the original "baptism" of the man himself. As long as the speaker is linked to this chain, they refer to Gödel, regardless of whether their descriptive beliefs about him are accurate. **Causal-Historical Chain**

Lastly, Proper names are **rigid designators**. They pick out the same individual in all possible worlds, independent of any accidental properties (such as who actually proved a specific theorem). **Rigid Designation**

Conclusion: Therefore, the reference of a name is not determined by the satisfaction of descriptions. The "ordinary man" successfully refers to Gödel because of the historical connection to the individual, even if his beliefs about that individual are entirely mistaken.